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UC-Berkeley plan to aid recycling 'one cup at a time'

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Author: UC-Berkeley; Amelia Heagerty | Section: News | 459 Words
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(*#_Company_Name_#*) BERKELEY, Calif. -- The University of California at Berkeley plans to buy 5,000 plastic mugs for its students in an effort to cut down on the use of disposable coffee cups.

The university gave nearly $10,000 to fund the UC-Berkeley Reusable Mug Program -- $7,500 of which will be spent on plastic coffee mugs for students.

The Associated Students of the University of California-sponsored program was finalized this weekend at the third annual UC-Berkeley Recycling Summit.

Backers of the program estimate it will save between 60,000 and 120,000 paper and plastic cups a year.

"Paper cup use is one of the greatest wastes we have on campus, so I hope these are mugs that people actually use during their time at Cal and beyond," said Graduate Student Assembly President Jessica Quindel, who proposed the program.

A few thousand mugs will be distributed during ASUC elections this spring, said ASUC President Jesse Gabriel. They will be available on a first-come-first-served basis.

The elections are a good fit for the mug giveaway because students must swipe their identification cards to vote. This will ensure only students get mugs, and that they only get one each.

Using the mug will be a double incentive -- students will be reducing waste and helping the environment, and they may get discounts at coffee shops for bringing their own mugs, Gabriel said.

ASUC officials want on-campus restaurants and cafes close to campus to offer a discount for students who use the mug instead of a paper cup.

Five of 10 coffee shops within two blocks of campus said they already offer a 10 cent discount to customers who bring in their own mugs, including Caffe Strada, Cafe Milano and Starbucks.

"We're trying to instill a culture of recycling and reducing waste on campus," Gabriel said. "UC-Merced is calling itself the environmentally friendly campus, but I think UC-Berkeley can be not only the free speech campus but also the environmentally friendly campus."

The program has been tried before. Six thousand students got mugs from the university in 2001, said Lisa Bauer, director of Campus Recycling and Refuse Services.

Bauer designed the original cups, 20-ounce plastic thermal mugs emblazoned with pro-recycling messages like, "Saving the planet one cup at a time."

The mugs are made from 40-percent recycled plastic and 60-percent nonrecycled plastic.

The mug program here at UC-Berkeley will follow in the footsteps of Harvard University, Brown University, the University of California at Davis and other universities across the nation.

"At Davis, people covet the mugs that come out," Bauer said. "They'll wait in lines for hours just to play a game to

win one of those mugs."

At the recycling summit, the university also established the Chancellor's Advisory Committee on Sustainability. The committee will meet monthly to discuss issues of recycling and other environmental issues.

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